Transformational Covenant Update

By Loren Cunningham

Introduction:

"This covenant calls Christians the world over to joyfully and compassionately share "that which we have seen…" change position of "to"

World
Opposing Magnetic forces: "Powerful attraction of sin," needs a parallel comparison, i.e. "competes against the compelling power of Christ's compassionate intervention into human affairs through His life and death" or "through the Cross."

Scope of Gospel
"As Creator, (need comma) God is Lord of all…"
Strengthen and clarify as this is new to some parts of the body?
"The church is called to bear witness to the Kingdom of God…" add: "in its fullness. Anything less than concern and truth for all spheres of life is to misrepresent the all-encompassing Lordship and compassion that Jesus lived and died to represent to us."

The peoples of the world
"Encompasses the ethne" (which is translated people groups, or ethnic groups). Next sentence seems to go back to individuals, "as people of god share with people…" Seems like you need to clarify your point here. Something like: "As the people of God faithfully witness to the love and truth of the gospel in whatever sphere of life they serve, individuals will be touched and transformed. As they live and incorporate biblical truth into all aspects of their lives, these truths will also touch and transform the very ethos, principles, standards and direction of whole spheres of life, thus impacting the ethne, or entire people group. This is the influence of salt, preserving society, and beginning to fulfill the mandate left us in the Great Commission to "disciple all nations."

Worldview
"As the inspired and authoritative word of God, (needs comma) the Bible…"

Implementation Through the Local Church AS IS
The Church – the body and bride of Christ – is God's principally ordained agent in advancing the Kingdom of God. The present expression of the Universal church is the living, worldwide body of redeemed people who have placed their faith in the person and work of Christ alone for the forgiveness of their sins, have been adopted as children of God, and have been given the Spirit of God as a pledge of their inheritance. The local Church is an intentional community-based expression of the universal church that meets regularly for worship, equipping, fellowship and service, and is the principal agent in carrying out God's agenda in the community where it serves. Each local Church is called to live as a Kingdom community, making the message of the kingdom credible as the incarnate Body of Christ in its particular locale. Nations are discipled as local Churches send their members into every sphere of society as servant leaders who witness to the reign of Christ over all creation and as new disciples are added to the church.

Revision:
The Church (literally "called out ones") is the body and bride of Christ, God's principally ordained agent in advancing the Kingdom of God. The present expression of the Universal church is the living, worldwide body of redeemed people who have placed their faith in the person and work of Christ alone for the forgiveness of their sins, have been adopted as children of God, and have been given the Spirit of God as a pledge of their inheritance.

The local church (modality) is the intentional, community-based expression of the universal church that meets regularly for worship, equipping and fellowship and service, making the gospel credible as the incarnate body of Christ in its particular locale. The missionary ("sent ones"), or "mobile church," (sodality) is called to bring the gospel to regions and spheres beyond their own locale (II Cor 10: 15,16 NAS). Together, these two expressions of the body of Christ universal are to see nations discipled.

The depth of the local church to equip, nurture and disciple individuals, combined with the breadth of the mobile church, bringing truth into new areas, brings a synergy of creativity and passion to see individuals redeemed and discipled and nations transformed, as truth permeates every sphere of society.

Witness in society
Every believer is called to participate in this task, not just the "religious professionals," (add quotes and comma) but average believers, (add comma) who ARE CALLED TO do far more than just send their prayers and money to fund a few.

"The new frontier is across vocations, (add comma) NOT JUST geographic boundaries…"

"Non governmental organizations hire religious and non-religious alike." What does this mean? Implies that governmental organizations are somehow different? Are you talking about NGOs particularly? Why highlight them when you're talking across all vocations?

"We covenant to be salt and light through our many opportunities to witness in society." Let's strengthen this to something like: "We covenant to be salt and light in every aspect of life, through every avenue of vocation and service available to us individually and corporately, in or communities and on the frontiers where the gospel is yet to be preached."

Least Reached
", when the body of Christ from every group stands before the throne worshiping God" ADD: (Rev 7:9).

"…little or no access to the gospel." NOW: it says "not access"

"We covenant through God's Spirit, we will seek to serve the Least-reached in transformative ways through our Churches, businesses, schools and organizations as we minister in word and deed in wider holistic witness and deeper discipleship." This sounds like an exhaustive list. Let's open it up so it's across every sphere, into every possible configuration of society. Also, it's also a bit of a problem because it sounds like we're going to reach the least reached through the witness of institutions in our societies. Most of the least reached are "out there" where there

are no institutions where Christians are a dominant influence. Something like; "We covenant to serve the least reached in transformative ways through every possible means to demonstrate the love and truth of the God of the gospel. We will seek to present the gospel to individuals through evangelism coupled with acts of mercy and creative, culturally relevant presentations. We will seek to serve and transform the corporate through bringing truth and love to bear on the pressing needs in every sphere of society. Examples would be the value of the individual as a cornerstone of curriculum and practice in the schools, the responsibility of servant leadership in government, etc.

Health
First sentence is a fragment. Rewrite to begin with: "Health is here defined as…"

Healing the whole person means restoring the image of God marred by illness, (take out and, add comma) thus restoring the person to a PERSONALLY FULFILLING AND productive role in society.

Youth
A new era dawns across the earth, (add comma) represented by more than half…

…heroic efforts of the past, (add comma) while avoiding the failings that have hindered…

Christian higher education
Starts with a fragment while the rest start with sentences. Just add "Christian education plays…"

"It is seen as a continuous, lifelong, and creative process; education has an almost unbounded transformational capacity." First of all, the sentence isn't clear. Secondly, it doesn't focus on the key truth that education does bring transformation, based on right or wrong values, perceptions. The point of the piece should be the importance of providing Christian education to shape this huge source of influence in a society. Rewrite to something like: "Education by its nature has an almost unbounded transformational capacity in society; providing biblical truths as the foundation for this ongoing process is the critical role of Christian higher education."

"The ultimate mission of Christian higher education is to enable people to experience new life in JC and thereby participate in a holistic redemptive/transformative task that is linked to the community and to the nation." I don't know that this is true, the mission of Christian higher ed isn't to bring salvation (enable people to experience new life in JC), but to equip those already saved to participate in transformation through applying biblical truths. I'd suggest a rewrite, something like: "The ultimate mission of Christian higher education is to provide believers the opportunity to grapple with biblical truths and their applications to all aspects of society. The goal must always be to serve and transform the nations as they serve as salt and light as individuals and influencing the values and direction of whatever sphere of society, they serve in."

The Arts
We affirm that creativity and life come from God, (add comma) and that His creative ways bring honor TO WHOM? and are based in love.

"…therefore, he is creative. Genesis 1:27" Should read "he is creative (Gen. 1:27)." Keep scripture references consistent. Same with following sentence: "…come from God (Ex. 31:3)."

"We acknowledge THAT the full scope of the arts…" (no "" and don't capitalize)

"The arts give cultural understanding to the eternal truths of the gospel and make invisible truths invisible." YES, this is very true, but has an even more compelling role in society. Add something like: The arts bring the truths contemplated by the philosophers into a form that impacts the imagination and emotions of any society, bringing transformation in whatever direction the message conveyed by the arts is founded upon. We must grapple with the implications of this powerful tool for shaping the values and beliefs of society, utilizing its influence to bring biblical truths to bear on every area of life."

Secular Higher Education
Re write 1st sentence a bit: A Christ-centered transformational vision for secular education is that they are changed from places of challenge and deconstruction for individuals and cultures into places of blessing. This will be accomplished as both faculty and students are won to Christ, nurtured….

"Alongside this personal spiritual discipleship, believers will also be trained to "thinks Christianly" about their fields and encouraged to develop…" Trained where and by who? Is this the role of ministry outside the university to train students in their area of study, or is the goal to transform the very content of the university to provide this input? Also: "Think Christianly" is a bit odd as a phrase; how about "believers will engage in the process of having their "minds renewed" (Rom 12: 1,2) to grasp biblical foundational truths and grapple with their implications in their area of study."

"We want to see the development of truly Christian education…" but you're writing here about secular education. Sounds like mixed goals…turn secular into Christian? Best grapple with that as it's a key question for this focus group: is your goal to work with the secular educational system, or is your goal to change it into a Christian educational system? Impacts your "we covenant" statement as well…

"…discourse will be transformed" discourse between who? Important distinctive.

Leadership
"…continues to learn of Christ by following Him, thus (drop and, add comma) growing in character..." Honestly, I don't see the distinctive role of this group. How is it unique to what all the others are doing, developing leaders in all areas of society? Seems a bit superfluous, not sure what their unique goals would be or how they would interface with the others. Seems like they need to formulate their thinking a bit further.

Microenterprise
Need to add scripture to opening statement to keep consistent with the others. Gen 1-3 somewhere (don't have a bible with me! ☹). Add: "In doing so, God gave human beings the capacity…"

"communion with him and with one another." Split up and with.

"…motivated by the compassion of the Lord Jesus by helping people meet their needs." Change to compassion of the Lord Jesus to equip people to meet their basic needs.

"We covenant to equip and enable the local church to play a key role…" Leave out local, as missions' groups often are the ones involved in microenterprise as development and evangelism in unpreach communities.